

24-System

A tactical survival-horror tabletop RPG framework centered on body commitment, positional control, and consequence-forward play.

This README compiles the current markdown rules and setting notes in `fiction/24system`.

Design Premise

The 24-System is built around these ideas: - Competent characters under escalating pressure - Choices about commitment and risk, not action-point optimization - Injuries that degrade capability over time - Fear that biases behavior without removing agency - Fiction-first resolution with fast adjudication

Core Resolution (`core.md`)

- Roll skill dice plus Leverage dice (if any)
- Result is sum of the two highest dice, plus flat bonus
- Compare against DC (raised by Pressure)
- Outcome bands:
 - Legendary Success (24+)
 - Partial Critical (any die at max)
 - Success
 - Miss
- Optional push-your-luck reroll:
 - Accept Minor Complication and reroll
 - If reroll still fails, escalate to Critical Failure and Major Complication

Leverage/Pressure replacement for advantage/disadvantage: - Leverage adds a bonus die by tier (d4 to d12) - Pressure increases DC instead of removing dice

Action Economy: RHLF / “Ralph” (`RLHF.md`)

Characters commit body anchors to perform actions: - L: primary hand - R: secondary hand - H: head (attention, targeting, intent) - F: feet (movement, balance, stance)

If an anchor is injured, related actions degrade. If disabled, those actions can become unavailable.

Combat Overview (`combat.md`, `defense.md`, `movement.md`, `weapons.md`, `wounds.md`)

Baseline Combat Concepts

- Guard is automatic when aware, unengaged, and not committing H
- Combat uses range states (Separated, Melee, Grappling), not grid distance

- Advancing into guarded space is contested
- Multiple guards stack by +2 DC per extra defender
- Dodge is preserved after normal movement, but Sprint/Leap normally consumes Dodge until next turn

Core Declared Actions

- Attack (L)
- Focused Attack (L+H)
- Full Martial Attack (L(R)HF)
- Advance (F)
- Move (F)
- Covering Fire (L+H, ammo, attention disruption)

Reactive Defenses

- Base defense (no active defense): attack DC 13
- Dodge: athletics-based avoidance, stamina cost
- Parry: melee-based interception/deflection, weapon risk
- Block: interception/absorption, strongest with shields

Cover and Concealment

- Concealment primarily affects perception/hit chance
- Cover at range increases DC
- Cover in melee is mostly active/interposed and depends on committed limbs/position
- Cover stacks with active defenses where applicable

Movement

- Movement Rate (MR) baseline 6 (human, unencumbered)
- Armor/packs apply only worst movement penalty source
- Sprint costs stamina for temporary MR increase
- Leg injuries reduce MR cumulatively

Weapons and Identity

Weapon identity is driven by partial-critical behavior and qualities: - Primary properties: Precision, Chopping, Crushing - Qualities: Reach, Parry, Brace, Improvised - One-handed baseline: 1 wound - Two-handed baseline: 2 wounds - Ranged tools differentiated by limb commitment and reload friction

Wounds, Armor, and Trauma

- Region tracks: each arm, head, shared legs, core
- Wound progression: OK -> Injured -> Disabled -> Missing (region-specific behavior)

- Armor is a single worn unit that converts wounds to stamina loss (Light/Medium/Heavy)
- Core wound thresholds drive failing, dying, death states

Stress Model (`fear-and-madness.md`)

Fear track runs 0-6: - Lower levels increase caution/hypervigilance - Mid levels introduce hesitation entering hostile danger - High levels reduce available anchor commitment - Top level causes breakdown/withdrawal

Madness is emergent from accumulated survival scars (Banes), not a separate meter.

Status Effects (`status-effects.md`)

Common tactical conditions are defined in one place: - Blind - Prone - Grabbed - Pinned - Restrained - Disoriented - Stunned - Silenced - Incapacitated - Unconscious - Bleeding

Character Growth

Character Creation (`charactercreation.md`)

- No attributes (no STR/DEX/INT)
- Assign 1 specialty, 1 strong, 2 competent skills
- Competent tier is $d10 + d12 + 2$ (Rank 1)
- Unassigned skills use vanilla roll ($2d12$)
- Choose 2 traits
- Add gear and narrative details

Advancement (`advancement.md`)

- No XP or levels
- Advancement at story-arc boundaries
- Declare one training focus per arc (skill or trait)
- Gain one skill tier (pyramid-limited) or one earned trait per arc

Skill Framework (`skills.md`)

Action-centric skills define what can be attempted: - Athletics - Melee - Ranged - Thievery - Lore - Social - Magic - Science

Key framework updates: - Contested checks: initiator rolls against defender average (rounded up) - Unified legendary conversion rule - Per-action duration tags (**Instant**, **Short**, **Extended**, **Scene**, **Sustained**) - Stealth awareness ladder and scene-based stealth handling

Perception Philosophy (`perception.md`)

No passive perception stat. Discovery is narrative and interaction-driven:
- Players ask specific questions and describe methods - Guide seeds fair clues for secrets/traps - Hidden features should be foreshadowed through sensory/environmental evidence

Magic Model (`spells.md`)

Spellcasting axioms: - Magic always works in type - Rolls determine manifestation quality and consequence, not binary success/fizzle - Failures escalate through backlash, danger, and cost

Current spell writeups: - Elder Sign - The Colour Out of Space - The Call - Pseudo-Apotheosis - The Unveiling

Playtest Materials

- `playtest-packet.md`: player-facing quick rule packet and expectations
- `playtest-characters.md`: fast combat reference

Setting / Thematic Documents

- `Atrocitas.md`: Atrocitas Sine Auctore concept (atrocities without authorship)
- `monsters/echo-born-other.md`: Echo-Born Other entity and stat block
- `authors-note.md`: design intent and authorship note
- `quote.md`: thematic line

File Index

- `advancement.md`: arc-based training and progression
- `Atrocitas.md`: cognitive-horror theorem and ontology note
- `authors-note.md`: author statement and design philosophy
- `charactercreation.md`: character flow, skills, traits
- `combat.md`: warding, range states, core combat actions
- `core.md`: outcomes, push-your-luck, leverage/pressure
- `defense.md`: active defense options, cover/concealment
- `fear-and-madness.md`: fear track and emergent madness model
- `initiative.md`: encounter order, initiative modifiers, and tempo effects
- `light-levels.md`: visibility categories from dim light through pitch darkness
- `movement.md`: MR, encumbrance, terrain, sprinting
- `monsters/echo-born-other.md`: monster ecology, behavior, stat block
- `perception.md`: narrative discovery and secret-door guidance
- `playtest-characters.md`: quick combat cheat sheet
- `playtest-packet.md`: player onboarding packet

- `quote.md`: thematic quote
- `RLHF.md`: body-anchor action economy
- `skills.md`: skill action vocabularies
- `status-effects.md`: common tactical conditions and their mechanical effects
- `spells.md`: spell axioms and examples
- `weapons.md`: weapon properties, qualities, ranged action economy
- `wounds.md`: hit locations, trauma ladder, armor conversion

Notes for Next Pass

Likely cleanup targets identified while compiling: - Standardize anchor naming (RHLF vs RLHF, and F vs “Legs (L)” in one defense section) - Resolve encoding artifacts (smart quotes/dashes rendering as mojibake in terminal output) - Align push-your-luck language between `core.md` and `playtest-packet.md` - Fill unfinished sections (**Blocking cover** heading) - Unify terminology for Guide/GM and action labels across reference docs